RELIGIOUS EXTREMISM AND SECTARIANISM

Religious extremism, sectarianism and Talibanisation did not emerge in days or months. It was the outcome of flawed policies introduced over the years. Mir (2009) delved into the past and present of jihadi culture and reached a conclusion that Talibanisation was in fact a result of the Islamisation process initiated by General Zia-ul-Haq from the 1970s to the 1980s. The fallouts of this process were not only disastrous for Pakistan but had adversely affected India, Afghanistan, the US and the UK. Jihadi organisations formed to fight against Soviet forces in Afghanistan and later turned towards Kashmir liberation and became too well entrenched in the society to be controlled by the civil governments. After 2001, the religious extremists became a force to be reckoned with, especially in the FATA and KP areas. The Pakistan Army managed to disperse the Taliban in Swat and FATA, but could not defeat them. Similarly, they could not prevent the spread of terror to the country's major urban centres such as Peshawar, Quetta, Lahore, Karachi, Rawalpindi and its capital, Islamabad.

Growth of religious extremism and sectarianism had been neglected by the authorities, which ultimately resulted in full-blown terrorism and insurgency in Pakistan. Khan (2011) stated that the most serious and lethal challenge for Pakistan could be militant extremism and terrorism in the country, which had badly affected the society and threatened the internal as well external security of Pakistan. Not only the flawed policies led to birth of extremism and sectarianism in Pakistan, but also the criminal neglect to check the rise of these tendencies made the situation bad to worse.

Only a holistic appraisal of TTP as insurgents operating in FATA, as terrorists carrying out their acts across Pakistan, backed by Al Qaeda, operating in the vastness of deep religious and sectarian extremism, clinging stubbornly to the divine mission of imposing *Sharia* in Pakistan and battering the economy (loss of $100 billion), stability, societal serenity and international image of Pakistan for more than a decade could portray it as an existential threat to Pakistan. The US's reaction in the form of drone attacks and military operations, like the one at Salala, in which 25 Pakistani soldiers were killed, further worsened the situation. Absence of any one of the above factors could make TTP look less formidable, resulting in incorrect assessment about